far looser formation than had been customary in Shaka's time. But they employed their rifles merely as an adjunct or alternative to the traditional throwing spear, shooting a scattered volley of bullets in the general direction of the enemy as a prelude to the final charge.

The Zulu empire was arguably already in decline before conflict with Britain brought about its downfall. Zulu chief Cetshwayo was nonetheless able to field some 40,000 warriors in an effort to repel the invasion of his territories by the British army in January 1879. The enemy was numerically inferior but armed with breech-loading rifles, field artillery, and Gatling guns.

Boldly seizing the initiative, on 22 January a force comprising around half of the entire Zulu army fell upon 800 British soldiers and their African auxiliaries camped in a defensively ill-prepared position at Isandhlwana. Despite suffering heavy losses, the Zulu pursued their attack, urged on by the *izinduna*. Even when the Zulu reached the British lines, they found their red-coated enemies formidable fighters with the bayonet. One Zulu later recalled that warriors hurled their spears or fired their rifles at the British rather than closing to stab them: "They avoided the bayonet; for any man who went up to stab a soldier was fixed through the throat or stomach". By sheer weight of numbers, however, the British were ultimately overrun and slaughtered. An almost simultaneous attack on a small British outpost at Rorke's Drift was repulsed, although fighting was at times again engaged at close quarters with bayonet against spear.

Militaristic pretentions
Utimuni, nephew of chief Shaka Zulu, in ceremonial dress. Shaka transformed the Zulu into an aggressive fighting force during his rule (1816–28).



DECLINE OF POWER

The scale of the loss of fighting men in these and subsequent battles was more than the Zulu could sustain. Ironically, when dispersed Zulu warriors mounted an uncoordinated harassment of British forces in defence of their homes, they had a large measure of success in this low-level guerrilla warfare. But Cetshwayo remained committed to pitting the magic-impregnated flesh of his warriors against British bullets in open battle, even though he knew victory was impossible.

A final bloody defeat at Ulundi in July brought the brief flourishing of Zulu military power to an end. The British annexed Zululand; Cetshwayo was captured and taken to England, where he was feted as a celebrity by the patronizing victors.

Glory at Isandhlwana
The Zulu were largely no match for the British army's artillery in 1879, but at Isandhlwana on 22 January, they survived heavy losses to triumph.

